



▲ Royal hunt

The 7th-century BCE Assyrian king Ashurbanipal is shown hunting lions in this frieze. It was an act with a wider symbolic meaning: the king was protecting his subjects as their *re'u* (shepherd) and also extending his dominion over the desert and the king of beasts.

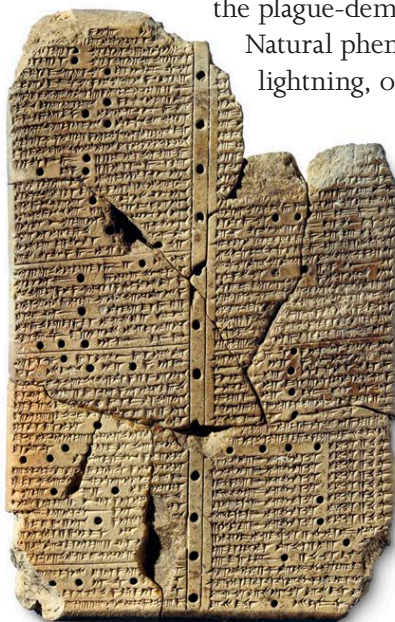
MAGIC ALL AROUND

Mesopotamian magic

The peoples of ancient Mesopotamia—the land within the Tigris-Euphrates river system, now mainly Iraq—lived in a world of magical practice. Sumerians, Assyrians, and Babylonians all sought help from exorcists and omen-interpreters to gain protection from malign supernatural entities and discover the future. From the time of the Sumerians, who founded the first cities around 4000 BCE, to that of the Babylonians over 3,000 years later, Mesopotamia was a land in which magic was part of everyday life.

► Maqlu (burning) tablet

Dating from around 700 BCE, this is the seventh of nine tablets. It contains chants for an *ashipu* (exorcist) to use to drive out witches who may have cursed a victim.



Beneath the official pantheon, including the likes of Enlil, the Assyrian sky god, and Ea, the god of wisdom, was a layer of demons, such as Lamashtu, who threatened pregnant women, and Namtaru, the plague-demon, who needed to be mollified.

Natural phenomena such as floods and lightning, or epidemic diseases, were not

scientifically understood despite Mesopotamian advances, and so people at all levels of society preferred supernatural explanations. Disasters were believed to be caused by *mamitu* (curses) laid by witches, by victims committing offenses (sometimes unknowingly) against the gods, or through unintentionally ignoring divine signs. Kings guarded against these occurrences by consulting